

■ **By Raj Chengappa**
in Wheeler Island, Orissa

In the summer of 2012, the roller-coaster relations between India and Pakistan suddenly go steeply downhill. Terrorists had launched a successful attack on the Indian Parliament, killing two Union cabinet ministers and 12 MPs. Pakistan's hand is clearly proven and, after a month, India goes to war. Pakistan threatens to use nuclear weapons if India doesn't stop the invasion. As Indian troops close in on Lahore, Pakistan launches a barrage of nuclear-tipped Ghauris to strike Delhi.

In the past, such an attack would have meant certain death and destruction for Delhi. But by that year, India is equipped with a sophisticated ground-based anti-ballistic missile system (ABM). The ABM system's long-range radar detects the barrage of Ghauri missiles within 30 seconds of lift-off. Five minutes later and 80 km above Delhi, the ABM batteries launch a set of interceptor missiles to strike them down. Four of Pakistan's Ghauri missiles are blown up and their fragments fall harmlessly. But two of them evade detection and head for the capital. As they arrive 30 km above Delhi, the Indian Army launches another bar-

THE NEW SHIELD

An Indian interceptor makes a perfect kill on its first launch giving the country capability to build a potent shield against incoming ballistic missiles. But there are hurdles to cross.

LEAN AND MEAN:
The AAD01 lifts off from Wheeler Island

